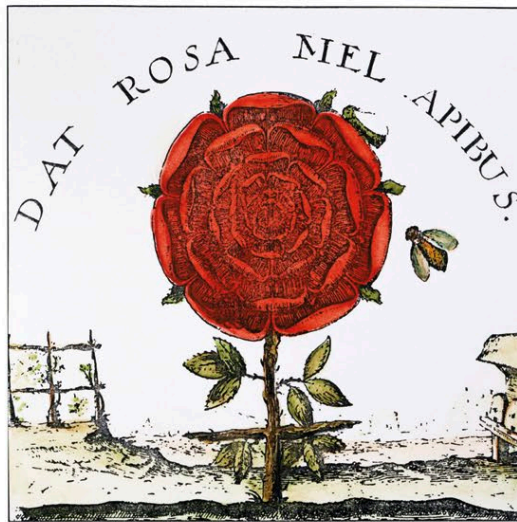


SECRETS OF THE ROSE AND CROSS

Rosicrucianism

The secret movement called Rosicrucianism, named after its emblem of a rose upon a cross, first began in the early 1600s. Rosicrucians professed that their followers had access to hidden mystic knowledge and could offer the key to transforming society—claims that made the movement the subject of intense speculation. Rosicrucianism also gave rise to related orders, which have lasted for centuries.



◀ Symbol of the society

The 17th-century, English astrologer and physician Robert Fludd became interested in Rosicrucianism and reproduced its rose-and-cross symbol on the title page of his book of 1629 called *The Highest Good*.

by religious warfare since the Reformation, they seized on the spiritual views of scholars such as German physician and occultist Cornelius Agrippa and Swiss alchemist Paracelsus.

Turmoil and transformation

Many people in Europe turned to millenarianism (the belief in a coming dramatic transformation of society) in the unstable decades that led up to the outbreak of the Thirty Years' War in 1618. Fearful for the future in a continent already ravaged

In this tense atmosphere, the appearance of three manifestos published in Germany between 1614 and 1616 caused a furore. The first—the *Fama Fraternitatis der Rosenkreuzer*—claimed to tell the story of German monk Christian Rosenkreuz (whose surname translates as Rosy Cross, see panel, below left) and of the brotherhood he formed. The *Confessio Fraternitatis* and *Chymical Wedding of Christian Rosenkreuz* built on the *Fama*'s tale of a secret magical society, adding references to Kabbalah, hermeneutic (interpretive) writings, alchemy, and other obscure mystical sources in an appeal to those who thought that both ancient and new knowledge could be combined to bring enlightenment to the world.

Brotherhood of man

The Rosicrucian manifestos spoke of a select (male) brethren who had passed the knowledge down the centuries, but no one knew who their author was. Later indications are that at least some of them were written by German theologian Johann Valentin Andreae. He attacked the Rosicrucians in public and dismissed their texts as a hoax, but he did admit in writing to having composed the *Chymical Wedding*. However, this admission was in a work that was not published until 1799, nearly 150 years after Andreae's death.

CHRISTIAN ROSENKREUZ (c. 1378–1484)

Legendary founder

The *Fama* alleged that Christian Rosenkreuz, a German monk, had made a pilgrimage to the Holy Land, and studied mystic arts and the Kabbalah in Arabia and Morocco. On his return in 1403, Rosenkreuz founded a brotherhood devoted to healing the sick and passing on the mysteries. He was said to have died in 1484, aged 106, and it was the discovery of his tomb in 1604, apparently lit by an ever-burning lamp, that led the Rosicrucians to publicize the manifestos and the society.

Mons philosophorum ("Mountain of Philosophers") was Rosenkreuz's tomb, guarded by a lion.

